

Radio Shack®

A Division of Tandy Corporation

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News Release News Release

For Release: July 27, 1988

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RS-89-009

TANDY INTRODUCES NEW NETWORKING STRATEGY FOR EDUCATION

FORT WORTH, TEXAS -- Tandy Corporation, the leader in educational networks and PC-compatible personal computers for the classroom, announces the introduction of SchoolMate, a powerful yet easy-to-use classroom networking strategy based on the graphics-oriented DeskMate™ interface, the MS-DOS® operating system, and the low-cost TandyLink™ network or the industry-standard 3Com® network.

SchoolMate is an integrated collection of applications and utilities designed specifically to assist students, teachers and administrators in organizing, creating and sharing information, software, time and resources.

Unlike most classroom networks, SchoolMate requires very little training and prior knowledge. Without sacrificing power, the graphics-oriented DeskMate interface eliminates confusing start-up procedures and the technical aspects of a network. SchoolMate provides its users with friendly pull-down menus and pop-up dialog boxes that can be accessed by either a mouse or via the keyboard.

SchoolMate's classroom management applications, Roster, Grade Book, Lesson Scheduler and Exam Maker, complement the network for a well-balanced system that addresses the unique needs of educators and students.

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The administrative system can be a stand-alone computer, a SchoolMate network workstation using stand-alone administrative software, or a station on a separate or connected network using multi-user administrative software. SchoolMate is capable of accepting and transferring basic student information from selected third-party administrative software packages.

The teacher workstation is designed with easy-to-use application tools to automate time-consuming classroom management processes. DeskMate teacher tools provided with the SchoolMate network include a Roster, which allows a teacher to maintain a list of student names and identification numbers for each class or the entire school; a Lesson Scheduler, by which the teacher can assign instructional applications to one student, a group of students or an entire class on a daily, weekly, bi-weekly or yearly basis; an Exam Maker, for building and storing multiple choice, true/false, matching, fill-in-the-blank and essay questions; and, a Grade Book, for tracking and automatic average calculation of weighted and non-weighted homework, quizzes, exams, projects and other assignments for teacher-specified periods or terms. Grade Book and Exam Maker may be checked in and out so that the teacher can enter information away from the classroom environment.

Student access on the SchoolMate network is limited to teacher-scheduled applications. The desktop user interface allows students to access these applications without exiting to confusing MS-DOS commands.

More than 80 existing education-specific applications currently run on the SchoolMate network and software publishers are being encouraged to release additional products.

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"Tandy has dominated classroom networking since the 1979 introduction of our first low-cost networking system known as the Network 1. A continuing series of faster, more sophisticated networking products to support Tandy^R computers has resulted in Tandy having the largest installed base of educational networks today," explains William D. Gattis, vice president of the Radio Shack^R Education Division.

"With SchoolMate, our newest classroom networking solution, we have focused on ease-of-use features and the specific needs of teachers, administrators and students. We are confident SchoolMate will be very well accepted by the educational community and Tandy will continue its innovative lead in classroom networking," Gattis added.

SchoolMate is compatible with the entire line of Tandy personal computers and can support up to 35 workstations and 2,000 student log-ins per network. Each workstation and file server require 640 kilobytes (Kb) of memory.

SchoolMate operates under low-cost TandyLink network hardware or 3Com's EtherlinkTM network. This hardware versatility allows schools to network SchoolMate with a minor investment and move to the high-capacity 3Com network environment as their needs increase. The user interface of DeskMate is the same for all configurations so the transition from one network to another requires little or no additional training.

The initial SchoolMate network installation includes both server and workstation modules. Supported applications may be installed at any time using a fully automated and easy-to-use "Install" process.

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The suggested retail price of SchoolMate (Cat. No. 25-1241), which includes 3Com's 3+ShareTM, is \$999.95. Prices are good at Radio Shack Computer Centers^R, Plus Computer Centers and participating stores and dealers nationwide.

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